

Dvar Torah Outline — Tehillim 117 (Hallel): Why the Nations Praise Hashem, and the Three Middot of Nissim– Gevurot–Chasadim

Abstract

This dvar Torah focuses on the “strange” logic of Tehillim 117: why the non-Jewish nations are commanded to praise Hashem specifically because “His kindness overpowered *us*.” Using the Gemara in Pesachim and the Maharal’s framing, the shiur resolves the question by splitting the pasuk’s praises into different categories: the nations praise Hashem for His demonstrations of power in the world (nissim and gevurot), while Israel uniquely praises for chasadim done *to us*. Along the way, it develops a conceptual map connecting nissim to Shem Havayah/rachamim, gevurot to din, and chasadim to chesed, and it critiques an attempted reading that “נבראים” here means specifically Klal Yisrael.

I. The opening problem in Tehillim 117: the pasuk sounds “messed up”

A. The text and its internal tension

- “הִלְלוּ אֶת־ה' כָּל־גּוֹיִם שִׁבְחוּהוּ כָל־הָאֲמִיּוֹת כִּי גָבַר עָלֵינוּ חֲסֵדוֹ וְאֶמֶת־ה' לְעוֹלָם הִלְלוּ־יָהּ”
(“Praise Hashem, all nations; laud Him, all peoples. For His kindness has prevailed over us, and the truth of Hashem is forever; praise Hashem.”)
- The intuitive question:
 - Why should “כָּל־הָאֲמִיּוֹת / כָּל־גּוֹיִם” praise Hashem **because** He was good to “עָלֵינוּ” (us, i.e., Israel)?
 - It feels disconnected: *their* praise seems motivated by *our* benefitting.

B. A second nuance: the phrase “גָבַר עָלֵינוּ חֲסֵדוֹ”

- connotes “גָבַר” **strength/overpowering** (almost: His chesed “overpowered” us).
 - The shiur flags this as a phrase that begs interpretation: why describe chesed in the language of gevurah?
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II. Maharal's approach: "עֲלֵינוּ" is not the hinge of the nations' praise

A. Re-reading the first half of the pasuk

- Maharal (as presented):
 - "הִלְלוּ אֶת־ה' כָּל־גּוֹיִם" — nations praise Hashem **עַם** "עַל הַנִּסִּים שֶׁעָשָׂה הַקָּדוֹשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא" (for the miracles He does with created beings).
 - "שִׁבְחוּהוּ כָל־הָאֲמִים" — nations laud Hashem **עַם** "עַל הַגְּבוּרוֹת שֶׁעָשָׂה הַקָּדוֹשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא" (for the acts of might He does with created beings).

B. Then "כִּי גִבֵּר עָלֵינוּ חֶסֶד" shifts focus to Israel

- The pasuk is effectively "split":
 - Nations: praise for Hashem's **nissim** and **gevurot** in the world.
 - Israel: "וְכָל שֶׁכֵּן אֲנִי יִשְׂרָאֵל... כִּי גִבֵּר עָלֵינוּ חֶסֶד" (*all the more so we, Israel... because His chesed has prevailed upon us*).
 - This resolves the initial disjunction:
 - The nations' obligation is **not** because of chesed to Israel.
 - The nations praise Hashem for what they can recognize of His **power**; Israel adds the dimension of **chesed done to us**.
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III. The Gemara in Pesachim as the explicit source for the question-and-answer

A. The Gemara asks the exact question

- "אִמָּה מַאי עֲבִידֵיהּ דְּמִשְׁבַּח?"
(What business do the nations have praising [Hashem]?)
- The question is driven by: "כִּי גִבֵּר עָלֵינוּ חֶסֶד"—why is that their reason?

B. The Gemara's resolution (as quoted)

- "הִלְלוּ אֶת־ה' כָּל־גּוֹיִם... עַל נִסִּים וְגְבוּרוֹת דְּעִבִּיד לֵהוּ"
(They praise Hashem for the miracles and mighty acts He performs.)
 - "וְכָל שֶׁכֵּן אֲנִי דְּבַעֲיִן לְשִׁבְחוּהוּ כִּי גִבֵּר עָלֵינוּ חֶסֶד"
(All the more so we must praise Him, for His chesed has prevailed upon us.)
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IV. Three categories emerge: Nissim, Gevurot, Chasadim

A. The shiur's organizing claim

- The Maharal/Gemara reading yields three “middot” being referenced:
 1. נִסִּים (miracles)
 2. גְּבוּרוֹת (mighty acts / din-like power)
 3. חֲסָדִים (kindnesses)

B. Addressing what is “missing” in the pasuk

- The shiur notes:
 - “הללו...” is not explicit in the words, but the Maharal supplies it as the meaning of “נִסִּים”
 - is also not explicit as a word, but is inferred from “גְּבוּרוֹת”.
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V. Mapping each category onto a divine “name”/ middah system

A. Why nissim are linked to the “Shem HaGadol”

- “כִּי הַנִּסִּים עוֹשֶׂה בְּשֵׁמוֹ הַגָּדוֹל כִּאֲשֶׁר יָדוּעַ”
- Concept developed:
 - Miracles are not just “extra power,” but reveal Hashem as **above the system of nature**.
 - This is associated with שֵׁם הוּיָהּ (י-ה-ו-ה) as the “essential name” behind all modalities.

B. Nissim as rachamim (relationship behind the system)

- The shiur explains:
 - רַחֲמִים means: even if the “system” would run a certain way, the Master of the system can **suspend** it due to relationship.
 - Therefore, miracles are rooted in that deeper level: “the face behind the mask.”

C. Gevurot and chasadim are more straightforward

- “וְגִבּוֹרוֹת נַעֲשׂוּ בְּמִידַת הַדִּין” — gevurot align with **din**.
 - “וְחֲסָדִים נַעֲשׂוּ בְּמִידַת הַחֶסֶד” — chasadim align with **chesed**.
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VI. Why nations can praise for nissim/gevurot even if they're not the recipients

A. The Maharal's distinction: praising "ability" vs praising "benefit"

- Even if miracles were done specifically for Israel, nations can still praise because:
 - **Miracles** "מורים על יכולתו של הקדוש ברוך הוא" (*indicate His capability*).
 - One can praise Hashem's greatness upon *seeing* that such acts happen in the world.

B. Core claim: for nations, the recipient is irrelevant

- The shiur illustrates:
 - A non-Jew might read Tanach and be moved by the splitting of the sea, plagues, etc.
 - Their praise is: "Look what God can do," not "How kind God is to Jews."

C. But chasadim are different: they are personal/received

- "אבל על החסדים יש לישראל לשבח, שעושה איתם חסדים"
 - Key distinction:
 - You praise a **chesed** in a fuller sense when you are the **recipient** of the chesed.
 - Therefore, Israel uniquely says: "כי גבר עלינו חסדו".
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VII. A side-controversy: does "נברואים" mean "Klal Yisrael" here?

A. The note attributed to Rav Hartman (as reported)

- An attempt was made to interpret "נברואים" as referring specifically to **ישראל**.

B. The shiur's rejection

- The speaker argues:
 - There is no strong precedent for the Maharal calling Israel "נברואים" in that way.
 - The later lines make it clear the nations are praising Hashem for **nissim/gevurot**, even though those are performed for Israel—because it showcases divine ability in the world.
 - Proposed resolution without redefining "נברואים":
 - can mean "נברואים"**human beings generally**; the miracles happened to involve Jews, but the nations' praise is about Hashem's power with "created beings."
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VIII. Limits of miracles for the nations (hashgachah and “systems”)

A. A framework raised in discussion

- The shiur references the idea (associated with classic hashgachah frameworks) that:
 - Open miracles and individualized providence are uniquely bound up with **Klal Yisrael**.
 - Other nations run more through “natural” channels / delegated systems (e.g., each nation has a sar/malach).

B. A qualification

- Even if a non-Jew experiences unusual salvation, it can be framed as:
 - happening **for the sake of Israel** (benefiting a Jew or the Jewish mission).
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IX. In Summary

- Tehillim 117's apparent contradiction is resolved by the Gemara/Maharal: the nations praise Hashem for **nissim and gevurot**, while Israel adds praise for **chasadim**.
- The phrase “**כִּי גִבֹר עָלֵינוּ חֶסֶד**” becomes a uniquely Jewish reason to praise—chesed is experiential and relational.
- The shiur maps the categories onto a middot system: **nissim** → **שֵׁם הוֹיָה/רַחֲמִים**, **gevurot** → **דִּין**, **chasadim** → **חֶסֶד**.
- need not be read as “Israel”; nations can praise Hashem's power as revealed in history “נִבְרָאוּ” even when Israel is the beneficiary.